

A Literature Review:
Kidney disease and the Ethics of Dialysis

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In the entirety of the world, around 35.5 million of the adult population suffers from chronic kidney disease (CKD). CKD has many causes, often genetic variations or consequences of life choices, ultimately resulting in fatality. Dialysis is a preventative measure that prolongs the life of kidneys by essentially performing their function.. This review discusses what exactly kidney disease is, what dialysis is, and if dialysis has any ethical concerns to the patients it aims to treat.

In the human body, kidneys perform to regulate what the body consumes and the natural production of fluid as well as waste. The severity of CKD can range from mild to debilitating. In instances where the CKD is detrimental, the treatment often requires life-long dialysis until a kidney transplant is available. In instances where the patient suffers even after achieving a kidney transplant, dialysis may be the only option (Mayo Clinic, n.d.). While the process of dialysis keeps people suffering from CKD alive long due to their medically-induced kidney function, the process is taxing on the body in all other aspects. Ideally, a patient should not have to implement a daily dialysis routine into their lives to stay alive.

What is dialysis?

Simply put, dialysis is a process which filters the body's blood and the kidneys of their excess toxins, since the kidneys are not able to do so on their own (Cleveland Clinic, 2021). In the instance a patient would need dialysis for kidney function, their kidneys would barely function, aka stage 5 kidney disease. There are two types of kidney disease including: peritoneal dialysis and hemodialysis. Both processes take upward of five hours, and must occur once per day to regulate the kidneys properly. Instances where the patient is waiting on a new kidney, the must complete dialysis to stay alive. In patients who have already received new kidneys and are tasked with dialysis, they must continue this process for the rest of their lives.

The ethics of dialysis

Patients who suffer from CKD and are aware of their declining health are given dialysis as more of a solution, rather than being informed of what exactly the process entails. While the process keeps the kidneys sufficiently running, dialysis has been said to lower the quality of life due to bills, risk of infection, and the long, extraneous process itself (Bertolini, 2016). Some may argue that patients should be thankful such processes exist to even stabilize the health of those in critical condition, but the likelihood of a patient undergoing dialysis to sustain themselves being content with their life is slim. Dialysis is more commonly given to the patients already in a very weak state, and with dialysis being such a taxing method of healthcare, this may cause more problems than solutions.

In conclusion, dialysis for patients who suffer from chronic kidney disease are given healthcare that may be much too harmful for the body to comply with, but that is their only option. Kidneys are essential for human life and therefore their upkeep is vital, however with advanced medicine we see in modern day, there must be alternative methods to research that can prolong the life of a CKD patient, without taking away from all other aspects of life. More research must be done on CKD patient regulation, and it can be concluded that dialysis is beneficial for a temporary solution, but asking a patient to continue the treatment for the rest of their days is almost inhumane. Patients deserve the utmost comfort and care when going through a debilitating disease that strips their identity. Dialysis is simply not the answer and hopefully one day there can be a solution to those in chronic internal pain due to the lack of solution for those with CKD.

References

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